fishermen crowded on the embankment. They passed a large outdoor market with stalls set up along the river. Léa couldn't believe the prices for carrots and onions—nearly double the cost since the war had begun—and there were only two stalls selling them. A breeze blew, and a few leaves, brown on the edges, tumbled along the ground as the sisters headed east and away from Orléans.

André was waiting next to the bench on Quai du Roi, two bicycles at his side. Last night, Rose had sketched him from memory. Léa had encouraged her to use the pastels, but Rose refused in case they would need to sell them. Still, she'd captured his likeness so much that Léa recognized him now immediately.

"*Enchanté*." André held out his hand to Léa. "Rose speaks so highly of you."

Léa smiled, shook his hand, relieved that he seemed genuine and down to earth. "I'm glad to meet you."

"I've brought an extra bike. It will save us time getting to the vineyard. Rose, you can go on my handlebars, and your sister can take the other one."

Léa hadn't ridden a bicycle in years and felt a surge of excitement. She trailed André down the towpath beside the Loire. She'd forgotten the pure thrill of wind streaming through her hair as she pedaled faster to keep pace.

Stopping momentarily on a bridge, he pointed to the locks filling with water as they prepared to lift a boat to the next level. Farther on, the towpath turned into coarse, chalky gravel.

On the left, they passed the white limestone tower of Saint-Jean-Baptiste Church, where the towpath split into upper and lower routes. Léa felt her shoulders drop, and the tension in her neck ease. Escaping the crowded city streets and the rubble marring the city center was a relief. She followed André onto the path toward the quiet village of Combleux. After passing the town square, they cycled up a gentle slope into rolling hills striped with vines.

They came to a farmhouse with thick, pale stone walls set in a horseshoe shape. Dense lavender bushes, their blooms long gone and now silver-tinted, grew along a wooden fence with a gate off its hinges. André cycled into the courtyard and dismounted, leaning his bicycle against the wall. Léa did the same.

Purple cyclamen and white crocus carpeted the ground. Léa carefully